

Expert speak. Or is it?

Picture this: A Web-savvy ecommerce enthusiast visits a popular portal to purchase an item that he wants to splurge some of his disposable income on. Seduced by several photos of the product clicked at different angles, our bedazzled online shopper is all but ready to hit the purchase button and hold the item in his eager hands (in a couple of days, as promised by the shopping portal). But the slightest sense of apprehension creeps into his dulled mind and he hesitates from clicking. What if he's making a mistake and the product isn't as good as he thought it was? Without batting an eyelid, he scrolls down the product page and scans through the "product reviews" section faster than an overzealous kid reaching for his favourite candy. After reading a few "happy" reviews of this product is worth its weight in gold, he feels reassured. How can anything possibly go wrong with a product vouched for by hundreds of satisfied customers? Without wasting any further time, our online shopper purchases the item.

Most of us are guilty of going through this routine at least once in our online shopping history – I know I have. However, with time and added online shopping experience, there's a few things that could've been done better.

Unless you're buying digital games, Kindle ebooks, or the like, online shopping is still a virtual mode of buying physical goods. What that means is that product images on shopping pages may be for representation only. You may not exactly get what you pay for. To stress this point, here's an extract from Myntra.com's 'exactness not guaranteed' clause which appears in its terms of use: "Myntra.com hereby disclaims any guarantees of exactness as to the finish and appearance of the final Product as ordered by the user. The quality of any products, Services, information, or other material purchased or obtained by you through the Website may not meet your expectations."

To convince fence sitters and lackadaisical shoppers from taking the plunge, ecommerce sites increasingly display product reviews or user testimonials on the product purchase page. Don't get swayed by them. Who's to say

whether all those hundreds of approvals were written by actual customers? How do you know they aren't manufactured or biased? Or written by paid writers? And do you honestly believe that anyone who bought a product online would go all out and criticize it and admit they made a mistake? Don't get easily swayed by positive "reviews", but pay attention to negative criticism directed either to the product or the shopping site.

In our quest to embrace online shopping and ecommerce, let's also spare a thought and celebrate the existence of large-format-retailers that give us the opportunity to touch and feel a product before purchasing it – that's something I do pretty regularly whenever I have to purchase something noteworthy and I need to reassure myself completely. Reading and looking at images of that much-awaited phone online just won't compare to walking into a mobile phone gallery and actually playing with it for a while. And even when we try to rate and review products the best way we know – with a lot of objective parameters – a small amount of subjectivity remains. For example, we may rate the typing experience on a laptop's keyboard to be "good but not the best", some other expert may rate the same keyboard at "better than most", but when you try it out at an electronic store you may not like the same keyboard. Your fingers are different than ours. Similarly, certain aspects of a product like its aesthetics and look and feel may strike differently to different users. Remember how beauty is in the eye of the beholder? Wise words that couldn't be more true.

But since we're pretty much in the business of reviewing products day in and day out, and with the accumulated knowledge of going through the greatest and most disastrous of products across different categories for over a decade, our readers can be rest assured of not having to buy a lemon. Ever. 



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